BASELINE → TREATMENT → FOLLOW-UP

Your treatment, tests and checks

Required regimen tests, symptom-triggered investigations and cancer-response tests serve different purposes. Ask who books each test and who explains the result.

Check	Before starting	Treatment visit	Between visits	Dose / phase review	After treatment
Blood and organ checks	Full blood count, kidney and liver tests; assessment of nerve symptoms when indicated. Review previous reactions to antibody infusions, red-meat allergy, tick bites and any cetuximab allergy-test results, as well as all medicines and allergies.	Regular full blood count, kidney and liver tests, with nerve assessment as indicated. The National Cancer Control Programme (NCCP) source does not give one universal testing interval: your unit must specify tests due before each planned visit. Cetuximab product information also requires electrolyte assessment before and periodically during treatment; the team confirms magnesium and other mineral checks.	Report new symptoms promptly; extra tests may be needed.	A held or changed dose needs a new clinical review and relevant repeat results.	Continue review of nerve symptoms, skin or nail problems and any abnormal blood or mineral results. The team sets the follow-up tests and disease assessments; this regimen does not mandate a universal post-treatment scan or tumour-marker timetable.
Treatment and appointments	Confirm the diagnosis, aim, prescription and actual calendar.	Cetuximab 500 mg/m^2 is infused on Days 1 and 15. The initial infusion has a slower maximum rate than later tolerated doses; total time depends on the prescribed dose. Plan for monitoring during and for at least 1 hour after each cetuximab infusion under the current medicine information; confirm the observation plan with your unit. Paclitaxel is usually 80 mg/m^2 over 1 hour on Days 1, 8 and 15; a consultant may select a 100 mg/m^2 starting dose for some patients. The actual prescribed dose and premedicines must be confirmed. Day 8 is paclitaxel only.	Follow the written home plan and keep pump or line appointments where applicable.	Paclitaxel is given on Days 1, 8 and 15, with cetuximab on Days 1 and 15 of each 28-day cycle. There is no scheduled treatment dose on Day 22. Both medicines continue while appropriate, until progression or unacceptable side effects; the protocol does not set a fixed total number of cycles.	Record the last dose and follow-up appointments.

Check	Before starting	Treatment visit	Between visits	Dose / phase review	After treatment
Mouth, weight and swallowing	Review oral health, weight, nutrition and safe swallowing.	Discuss mouth pain, intake, weight and hydration.	Report poor drinking, choking or weight loss promptly.	Dietitian and swallowing plans change with symptoms and recovery.	Continue dental, nutritional and swallowing support when needed.
Cancer assessment	Agree staging, pathology and any relevant disease tests.	Discuss symptoms and the planned response review.	Scans or examinations may be added if symptoms require them.	The team sets imaging and cancer-assessment timing.	No universal imaging interval or routine tumour-marker panel is imposed by this regimen.

The team arranges and reviews tests. This guide shows expected timing; it does not record completed appointments. NCCP 00696 v2: official regimen · EMA: Erbitux product information and patient leaflet

Tests in your plan

Full blood count

WHEN

At baseline and regularly; your team specifies visit-by-visit timing

Checks infection-fighting cells, oxygen-carrying cells and platelets.

Kidney and liver tests

WHEN

At baseline and regularly; your team specifies visit-by-visit timing

Guide safe treatment and identify organ problems.

Electrolytes, including magnesium

WHEN

Before and periodically during cetuximab under product information; no exact universal interval is stated in this NCCP protocol

Cetuximab can lower minerals; the team agrees which tests and replacement are needed.

Imaging and tumour-specific tests

If part of your plan

WHEN

As individually arranged for the disease and symptoms; no universal marker panel or imaging interval

Assesses the cancer rather than whether a treatment-day blood count is safe.

THE WHOLE TREATMENT JOURNEY

Paclitaxel Days 1, 8, 15 + cetuximab Days 1, 15 · 28-day cycle: treatment and checks

Recurrent and/or metastatic head and neck squamous cell carcinoma under NCCP 00696.

Paclitaxel is given on Days 1, 8 and 15, with cetuximab on Days 1 and 15 of each 28-day cycle. There is no scheduled treatment dose on Day 22. Both medicines continue while appropriate, until progression or unacceptable side effects; the protocol does not set a fixed total number of cycles.

Read from left to right. Columns show stages, not equal lengths of time. This is a general plan: no dates or personal information are needed. Your team confirms which steps apply and arranges appointments.

Treatment, tests and reviews across the course

Care / check	Before starting	Treatment visit	Between visits	Dose / phase review	After treatment
Blood and organ checks NCCP	Full blood count, kidney and liver tests; assessment of nerve symptoms when indicated. Review previous reactions to antibody infusions, red-meat allergy, tick bites and any cetuximab allergy-test results, as well as all medicines and allergies.	Regular full blood count, kidney and liver tests, with nerve assessment as indicated. The NCCP source does not give one universal testing interval: your unit must specify tests due before each planned visit. Cetuximab product information also requires electrolyte assessment before and periodically during treatment; the team confirms magnesium and other mineral checks.	Report new symptoms promptly; extra tests may be needed.	A held or changed dose needs a new clinical review and relevant repeat results.	Continue review of nerve symptoms, skin or nail problems and any abnormal blood or mineral results. The team sets the follow-up tests and disease assessments; this regimen does not mandate a universal post-treatment scan or tumour-marker timetable.

Care / check	Before starting	Treatment visit	Between visits	Dose / phase review	After treatment
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What each check is for

1 Combination treatment

Follow your agreed treatment calendar

Paclitaxel and cetuximab aim to control head and neck cancer that has returned or spread and may help symptoms. Your team explains expected benefit, uncertainty and options in light of your previous treatment.

Ask / act: Confirm active medicines, written support plan and review criteria.

Sources: NCCP

2 Day 8 within the same 28-day cycle

Follow your agreed treatment calendar

Paclitaxel and cetuximab aim to control head and neck cancer that has returned or spread and may help symptoms. Your team explains expected benefit, uncertainty and options in light of your previous treatment.

Ask / act: Confirm active medicines, written support plan and review criteria.

Sources: NCCP

At the next review, ask

- Which treatment phase am I in, and what happens next?
- Which test is expected next, who arranges it, and who explains the result?
- Who should I contact if an expected appointment has not arrived?

This map does not show whether a test has been ordered, booked or completed. Do not wait for a scheduled test if you develop new symptoms.

Sources checked 2026-11-10 · Source reconciled draft; independent clinical, oncology-pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending · SACTCheck v0.84.47